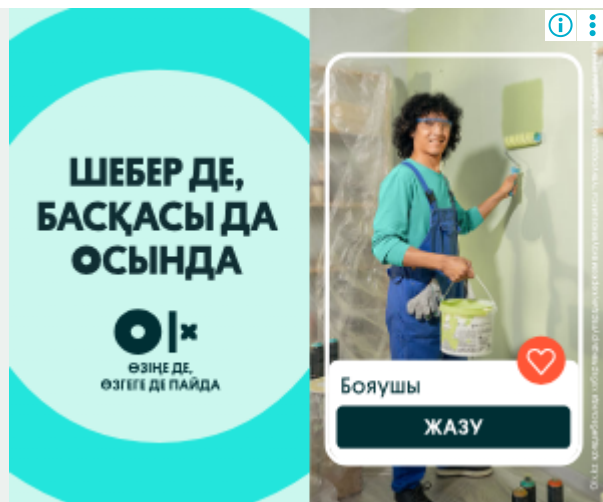




AI



Zuckerberg says people without AI glasses will be at a disadvantage in the future



IMAGE CREDITS: META

Echoing sentiments shared in his [“superintelligence”-focused blog post](#) this morning, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg expanded on his bullish ideas that glasses will be the primary way users interact with AI in the years ahead. During Meta’s second-quarter earnings call, the social networking exec told investors he believes people without AI glasses will be at a disadvantage in the future.

“I continue to think that glasses are basically going to be the ideal form factor for AI, because you can let an AI see what you see throughout the day, hear what you hear, [and] talk to you,” Zuckerberg said during the earnings call. Adding a display to those glasses will then unlock more value, he said, whether that’s a wider, holographic field of view, as with [Meta’s next-gen Orion AR glasses](#), or a smaller display that might ship in everyday AI eyewear.

“I think in the future, if you don’t have glasses that have AI — or some way to interact with AI — I think you’re ... probably [going to] be at a pretty significant cognitive disadvantage compared to other people,” Zuckerberg added.

Meta has been focused on building smart glasses, like its [Ray-Ban Meta glasses](#) and, more recently, [Oakley Meta glasses](#). The glasses let users listen to music, take photos or videos, and ask Meta AI questions, including about what they’re seeing, among other things. These wearables have turned

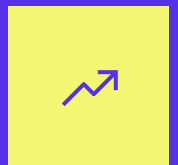
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into a surprise hit for the company, as revenue from sales of the Ray-Ban Metas [more than tripled year-over-year](#), according to glasses giant EssilorLuxottica.

But Zuckerberg believes there's more to be done with displays.

"This is ... what we've been maxing out with Reality Labs over the last 5 to 10 years — basically doing the research on all these different things," he said.

The Reality Labs division has been a money pit for the company, so it's not surprising the exec wants to justify its cost to investors by positioning it as a bet on the future of AI and consumer computing in general. For example, Meta said Reality Labs' [operating loss was \\$4.53 billion](#) in the second quarter. Since 2020, the unit has lost [nearly \\$70 billion](#).

However, the future of consumer AI may or may not be in the form of glasses. This spring, OpenAI acquired former Apple executive [Jony Ive's startup in a \\$6.5 billion deal](#) to build new consumer devices for interacting with AI. Already, other startups have dabbled in this area as well, including in form factors like AI pins — [such as with Humane's flop](#) — and pendants, like those from [Limitless](#) and [Friend](#).

Glasses, for now, seem to make the most sense, as many people already wear them, and they're more socially acceptable. But the world didn't know it needed smartphones, either, until someone dreamed them up. The next AI device could be something we can't even imagine yet.

Still, Zuckerberg cheers the idea that glasses are going to be it.

"The other thing that's awesome about glasses is they are going to be the ideal way to blend the

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physical and digital worlds together,” he said. “So the whole Metaverse vision, I think, is going to ... end up being extremely important, too, and AI is going to accelerate that.”

Topics: [AI](#) [glasses](#) [Hardware](#) [Mark Zuckerberg](#)

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Sarah Perez

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Meta’s Ray-Ban Stories now let users make calls and send messages with WhatsApp



Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg **announced** today that the company is launching more hands-free features for its Ray-Ban Stories smart glasses. Starting today, Ray-Ban Stories users can make calls, hear message readouts and send end-to-end encrypted messages with WhatsApp. Meta added similar functionality for Facebook Messenger last year. Zuckerberg also announced that users will soon be able to directly reply to Messenger or WhatsApp messages with voice commands.

With this new update, users can make calls and send messages on WhatsApp hands-free by saying “Hey Facebook, send a message to...” or “Hey Facebook, call...” You can also listen to new messages you receive on WhatsApp. Once you get a new message, the glasses will say: “New message on WhatsApp from <name>: Is now a good time to talk?” In a future update, Meta plans to add the ability to directly reply to incoming messages on Messenger and WhatsApp, hands-free by saying: “Hey Facebook, reply” after the glasses read out a new message.

The company notes that your personal messages and calls are automatically secured with end-to-end encryption, which means WhatsApp, Meta and third parties can’t read or listen to them. After the voice assistant identifies a voice command related to WhatsApp calling or messaging, the voice transcript and audio is not stored on any server.

IMAGE CREDITS: LUGAS MATNEY / TECHCRUNCH

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Meta also say it plans to expand WhatsApp and Messenger support for French and Italian speaking Ray-Ban Stories users this year.

Today’s update is rolling out to both the Facebook View iOS and Android app in phases and will be available to everyone in the coming days. Meta says users should make sure they have the latest app update and firmware on their glasses.

Meta [debuted its Ray-Ban Stories](#) smart glasses in September 2021 in partnership with eyewear giant EssilorLuxottica. The glasses allow users to snap photos and videos with the two onboard 5 MP cameras, listen to music with in-frame speakers and take phone calls. The glasses need to be connected to an iOS or Android device for full functionality, though users can take and store hundreds of photos or dozens of videos on the glasses before transferring media to their phones via Facebook’s new View app. The twin cameras allow users to add 3D effects to their photos and videos once they upload them to the app.

The smart sunglasses come in three classic Ray-Ban styles, with a number of color and lens combinations. The Ray-Ban Stories are fully compatible with prescription lenses. The glasses start at \$299, with polarized and transition lens options available at a higher price point.

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At the time of the launch, Meta indicated that the device was a stepping stone for its AR ambitions and an effort to get users acquainted with the idea of high-tech glasses.

The launch of the new features comes as [Meta is said to be scaling back](#) its plans for its AR glasses, according to a recent report from [The Information](#). The company reportedly had originally planned to launch the first version of its AR glasses, which are codenamed Project Nazare, in 2024. However, employees have been notified that Meta no longer plans to commercially release the AR glasses due to efforts to cut back on heavy investments in its Reality Labs and AR/VR division. The company plans to instead use the first version of the AR glasses as a demonstration product, as opposed to a commercial one. Meta is now planning to prioritize the release of the second version of the AR glasses, codenamed Artemis.

Review: Facebook’s Ray-Ban Stories make the case for smart glasses



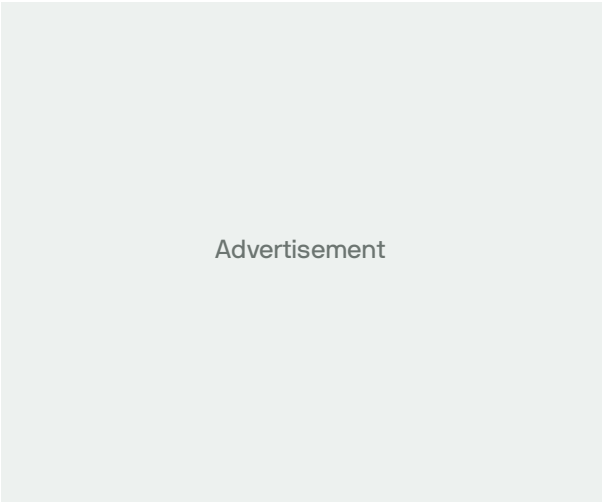
Facebook’s first pair of smart glasses doesn’t feel like much of a Facebook product. You won’t find the Facebook logo emblazoned on them or even its name in small print by the serial code. They aren’t “Facebook Stories” or “Ray-Ban’s Facebook Stories” or even “Ray-Ban Stories in collaboration with Facebook.” Unlike other Facebook-designed hardware like ... Continue reading

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Aisha Malik
Consumer News Reporter | 

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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AI



Meta previews generative AI tools coming to WhatsApp, Messenger and Instagram, plus internal AI tools

Sarah Perez — 8:17 AM PDT · June 9, 2023

IMAGE CREDITS:

BLOOMBERG / CONTRIBUTOR / GETTY IMAGES

Meta this week showcased its work on new generative AI technologies for its consumer products, including Instagram, WhatsApp and Messenger, as well as those being used internally at the company. At an all-hands meeting, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced several AI technologies in various stages of development, including AI chatbots for Messenger and WhatsApp, AI stickers, and other tools that would allow photo editing in Instagram Stories, in addition to internal-only products, like an AI productivity assistant and an experimental interface for interacting with AI agents, powered by Meta's large language model LLaMA.

Latest in AI

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AI



Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

Sarah Perez - 11 hours ago

AI



First impressions of Alexa+, Amazon's upgraded, AI-powered digital assistant

[Axios](#) had first reported the news of the consumer-facing AI agents and photo-editing tools, specifically. But the larger presentation touched on a number of areas where Meta is developing AI technologies and commentary about where it sees this space going.

In addition, the company announced it's planning to host an internal AI hackathon in July focused on

Sarah Perez - 12 hours ago

AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 12 hours ago

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Engineering, Generative AI at Meta.

For instance, Meta's AI chatbots, or AI agents as they're being called, would allow consumers to interact with AIs that had unique personas and skill sets that could help and entertain people.

This is one of the areas in the consumer market that's been gaining increasing attention and investment in recent months, as demand for AI chatbots has taken off. One leading app in this space, Character.AI, developed by researchers who helped build [LaMDA](#) (Language Model for Dialogue Applications) while at Google, [gained over 1.7 million new installs](#) in less than a week on the market, it said. The company is backed by [\\$150 million](#) in Series A funding, led by Andreessen Horowitz (a16z). However, the app competes with

numerous other chatbot apps on the App Store providing similar functionality, ranging from those that allow users to develop their own AI characters, like Replika, to those that serve a particular purpose, like writing helpers or personal assistants.

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Meta plans to first release its AI agents on Messenger and WhatsApp but sees a broader future for such technologies that may see them expanding across its family of applications, and

eventually to smart glasses, Zuckerberg told employees. In those cases, the vision is that consumers would wear some sort of smart glasses — similar to Meta’s Ray-Ban Stories — to interact with the agents via voice.

As one example, a user at an airport could ask the agent what to do in the city for a couple of hours during a layover. Users could also prompt the agent to respond to queries in specific styles, as you could with a text-based agent. While Ray-Ban Stories are sunglasses — and not likely appropriate for smart glasses with AI chat — Meta has been developing other tech in this space, like [Project Aria](#) and efforts from [its Research Lab](#).

In addition, Meta said in the meeting it was experimenting with AI that would allow users to engage with a text prompt in order to modify their own photos for sharing in Instagram Stories. This also comes on the heels of significant consumer interest in AI photo editors, including the viral trend of AI avatars that kicked off last year, [sending apps like Lensa AI](#) to the top of the App Store. Apps that turn [words into AI photos](#), like Wonder, are also popular across the App Store.

In Meta’s case, the plan is to introduce AI stickers in Messenger, which could be generated from a text prompt. Another project, which has yet to enter internal testing, would allow users to type in a prompt as to how they want to edit a photo they’re planning to post to Instagram Stories.

For consumers, the benefit of Meta’s entry into this space is that these tools would be made free to use, thanks to Meta’s ad-supported business. Most competitive apps on the App Store offer only limited AI edits for free, but then push users into ongoing subscriptions to try all the features.

The meeting also showcased other ways Meta was using generative AI for internal purposes.

This included an experimental internal-only interface to an “agents playground” powered by its large language model LLaMA where Meta employees could have conversations with AI agents and then provide feedback to help the company improve its systems. It’s also working with MetaGen, which provides APIs for Meta’s text and image generation models for experimental use and prototyping, and Metamate, an internal productivity assistant that pulls information from internal sources to perform various tasks, driven by users’ text prompts.

For instance, developers could ask Metamate to help it find bugs in products they were dogfooding, while others could use it to help find space in their calendar by shifting meetings around.

Meta confirmed to TechCrunch its initial consumer-facing tools will arrive this year, likely sometime in the next few months.

“In the last year, we’ve seen some really incredible breakthroughs — qualitative breakthroughs — on generative AI and that gives us the opportunity to now go take that technology, push it forward, and build it into every single one of our products,” Zuckerberg said during the presentation. “We’re going to play an important and unique role in the industry in bringing these capabilities to billions of people in new ways that other people aren’t going to do, he added.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI](#) [Apps](#) [Facebook](#) [Generative AI](#)

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | X butterfly @ in

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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IMAGE CREDITS: META /

HARDWARE

Meta Connect 2023: Everything you need to know about Quest 3 VR, Ray-Ban smart glasses and Meta AI

Christine Hall — 12:26 PM PDT · September 27, 2023

Meta's annual [Connect](#) conference started today, and this means lots of new hardware. Are you ready for an update on [Meta Quest 3](#)? Didn't have time to [tune in live](#)? That's okay — we summed up the most important parts from the keynote below. And also what was missing. By that, of course, [we mean the metaverse](#).

Meta Quest 3

Consider this a bonus treat for having to wait an extra 30 minutes for the keynote to begin. [Meet Meta's Quest 3](#), the headset model with improved passthrough tech, higher resolution displays and better graphics. There was also a tease for [Meta Quest for business](#).

Full-color passthrough tech has 10x as many pixels as its predecessor.

110-degree field of view.

System is powered by the newly announced [Qualcomm Snapdragon XR2 Gen 2 chip](#).

Retails for \$500.

Comes with [six months of the Quest+ VR subscription](#).

Our U.S. managing editor Darrell Etherington [tested out the Meta Quest 3 VR](#). Find out if he liked it.

[Headspace](#), a “virtual playground for your mind,” is coming.

Learn about how “[augments](#)” can personalize your physical space.

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IMAGE CREDITS: QUALCOMM

Xbox Cloud Gaming

With the hardware news, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced the next generation of Meta Quest software. [Roblox](#) included.

A virtual screen that can float in either a virtual or mixed-reality space.

Appears to be reposition-able and resizable.

Coming in December.

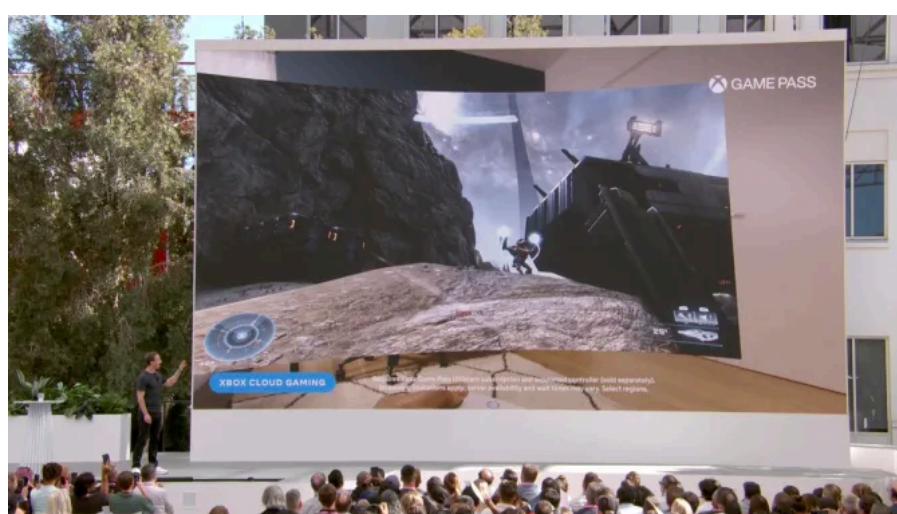


IMAGE CREDITS: META

Emu

Meta's new foundational model for image generation, Emu, comes with some fun things. One is [generative AI stickers](#) that are coming to Meta's messaging apps. It will allow users to create unique

AI stickers in a matter of seconds across Meta apps, including WhatsApp, Messenger, Instagram and even Facebook Stories.

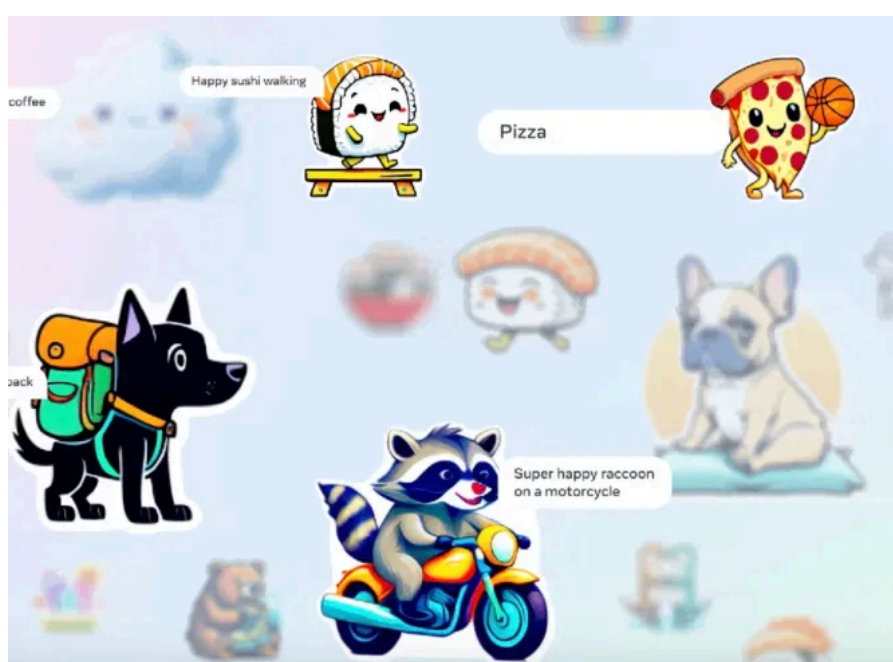


IMAGE CREDITS: META

Ray-Ban Meta smart glasses

Looking for some new glasses? Meta has you covered with its new [Ray-Ban smart glasses](#).

Two round modules on the side of either eye include a 12-megapixel camera and an LED light that flips on to alert others that you're recording.

You can livestream to friends and followers from the glasses.

There are more than 150 design combos possible when you factor in frame color, style and lenses.

You can preorder now in certain markets. The price starts at \$299 for standard lenses. Polarized run \$329 and transitions \$379.

Coming soon: [the ability to translate text](#).

IMAGE CREDITS: META

Meta AI

We can tell Meta is angling for a seat at the AI chatbot table with the launch of a host of new AI-powered bots across its messaging apps. One is an AI assistant called Meta AI, which will soon come to Meta's newly announced Quest 3 VR headset. It can help plan a trip with friends in a group chat, answer general-knowledge questions, and search the internet across Microsoft's Bing to provide real-time web results.

Also today, Meta launched [AI Studio](#), a platform that'll let businesses build AI chatbots for the company's messaging services, including Facebook, Instagram and Messenger. Starting with Messenger, AI Studio will let companies "create AIs that reflect their brand's values and improve customer service experiences," according to the company. It is only available in alpha to start.

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IMAGE CREDITS: META

Speaking of AI, get a load of the [vast list of celebrities and influencers](#) who have signed on to let Meta use their likeness for some fun. There are now 28 AI characters based on famous people —

but built entirely from AI — from across the worlds of sport, music, social media and more.

IMAGE CREDITS: META

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